

Setting up Dovecot, the IMAP Server

A mail server is a computer on the network that acts as a virtual post office for emails. In the previous article published in February 2014, the author had explained how to set up an email server on Gentoo Linux using Postfix and Dovecot. This part guides readers on how to configure Dovecot, the IMAP server.



In Gentoo (and probably every other distro), details about Dovecot configuration are available in `/etc/dovecot`. The directory contains a few files and a `conf.d` directory for extra configuration of various aspects of the server. The configuration files are well documented with comments.

The main `dovecot.conf` file is something like this:

```
protocols = imap lmtp
listen = <ip>, 127.0.0.1
login_greeting = ABC mail service
verbose_proctitle = yes
shutdown_clients = yes
!include conf.d/*.conf
```

The protocols line specifies the protocols it must serve. It's been set to LMTP and IMAP. LMTP, as described in the first article in this series, is the local mail delivery protocol used by Postfix to transfer mails to Dovecot. You can add one more protocol there—the traditional POP3. But in the age of mobile devices and easily accessible email, I don't think anyone really uses POP3 as it involves downloading everything to a single machine.

You should put your public IP and localhost there. If you want to offer only a Web mail service, you can leave out the public IP. Dovecot must listen on 127.0.0.1 because that's where our Web mail client (Roundcube) will connect. We'll look into the configuration of Roundcube later.

The login greeting is nothing specific, so use anything you

like. It is a protocol level greeting message, which is not seen or shown by most (or all) clients that interact with a mail server.

Verbose proctitle: As the documentation in the configuration file says, the `verbose_proctitle` option shows mailbox information in process names in `ps` (the process status command), which is automatically available in tools like `top`/`htop`. In a virtual mail setup, it will be hard to distinguish the load offender when only the username and IP is shown. I recommend enabling this.

Shutdown clients: This is a rather debated setting—whether or not Dovecot should kill client connections when the master process shuts down. If this is enabled, for a short period of time during upgrade, the mail server will be unavailable. If it is disabled, it will be available throughout—but existing processes (open connections) will not get the update. What happens if a security fix is missed out as a result? I prefer security to availability, so recommend that this is enabled.

Now, in the same directory, we have `dovecot-sql.conf.ext`. In this file, Dovecot is configured to access the SQL database. The same connection configuration (only the connect option) must be specified in the beginning of `dovecot-dict-sql.conf` as well (which is used for expire and quota plugins).

```
driver = pgsql
connect = host=/run/postgresql dbname=mail user=mail
password=<password>
default_pass_scheme = SHA512-CRYPT
password_query = SELECT * FROM active_users_passdb WHERE user
```